Framing in an Official History: The Collocates of Wei Zhongxian in the Mingshi

Question and Source

The Mingshi (明史) is the official history that the Qing court compiled for the previous dynasty, completed in 1739. While it writes the history of the Ming, it also contains an explanation for the fall of the Ming, so it is not a neutral record. The question I want to answer is therefore: how does the Mingshi "frame" Wei Zhongxian (魏忠贤)? "Framing" here means how a history builds a fixed image for a person by selecting and combining words. An official history has a clear political position, and the wording itself is a narrative device; if some words repeatedly appear around Wei Zhongxian, they form a semantic field kept on purpose. So my main argument is that the Mingshi writes Wei Zhongxian as an extreme example of eunuch misrule: he uses forging edicts (矫旨) and transmitting edicts (传旨) to exercise a borrowed imperial power, relies on his faction (其党) and living shrines (生祠) to build a network, uses dismissal (削籍) and removal from office (落职) to remove his opponents, and is finally condemned by the treason case (逆案). This set of words agrees with the Qing explanation that the fall of the Ming was due to women and eunuchs seizing power (婦寺竊柄).

The source is the full text of `data/明史.txt`, taken from the course repository; the content is the Wikisource transcription of the Mingshi, and it belongs to public domain. The whole book is about 3.28 million characters, in 332 juan. I use it because, as an official history that the Qing wrote for the previous dynasty, it has to give an explanation for the fall of the Ming, and this is exactly what I want to examine.

Processing and Method

For processing, I first delete the content that is not the main text, then use opencc to convert to simplified, split the sentences by the end punctuation, segment with jieba, remove the punctuation, and keep only the sentences of five words or more; I also make another control set of three words or more. The segmenter does not know many personal names, so I use a user dictionary to fix the key names and terms, check about twenty-five sentences by eye, and also run once with the abbreviated name Zhongxian (忠贤) merged into the target word. To judge whether two words are really related, I put each collocate and the target word into a 2×2 contingency table and use Fisher's exact test to get the p-value; because several thousand words are tested at once, I use Benjamini–Hochberg to correct and keep only those with an adjusted $p < 0.05$. For significance I use log-likelihood and for strength I use logDice, and the two rankings are often not the same. I limit the word length to at least two characters and the co-occurrence

to at least three. To compare different "near", I run five times in total: window 5+5, 10+10, same sentence, merged abbreviation, and the three-word corpus.

Results and Interpretation

The window 5+5 list has mainly two kinds of words. One kind is relations and names, such as Yang Lian (杨涟), Ke Shi (客氏), Donglin (东林), and his faction; the other kind is narrative verbs, such as forging edicts, transmitting edicts, dismissal, building shrines (建祠), and the treason case. Words describing character and appearance are almost absent. When the window is enlarged to 10, dismissal and removal from office rise in position, which shows these associations often appear across sentences. The rankings of the two measures also start to separate: after merging the abbreviation, Tianqi (天启) enters only the strength list, and great anger (大怒) enters only the significance list. The most obvious change is forging edicts, which rises from 15th to 2nd after the abbreviation is merged, and transmitting edicts rises to 6th, which shows the abbreviation sentences are mostly about actions like falsely passing imperial orders. The result of the three-word control is basically the same as the main set.

From the results, after summarizing, we can see that the Mingshi mainly uses two lines, "relations" and "actions", to define Wei Zhongxian.

The first line is "relations": the one on top of the list, Yang Lian, is exactly the person who impeached him, not his follower. The book repeatedly writes that Yang Lian impeached Wei Zhongxian for twenty-four great crimes (二十四大罪) (juan 22), so the narration about Wei Zhongxian is to a large extent developed from the impeachment and the purge, using the angle of the victim. The other names also belong to this conflict: Donglin and Zhao Nanxing (赵南星) on the impeachment side, Cui Chengxiu (崔呈秀) and Shi Sanwei (石三畏) attached to him. So Wei Zhongxian in the Mingshi is not an independent person with character, but a center of conflict.

The second line is actions. These actions share one common precondition: they cannot be done without the name of the emperor. The most common are forging edicts and transmitting edicts; the action seems to come from him, but the authority comes from the emperor. This could work also because of his own condition. Meng Sen (孟森) mentions in this section that Wei Zhongxian was illiterate, and in fact let Wang Tiqian (王体乾) and others read the memorials and pass the edicts for him, and the emperor often pushed the matters to them; the power slowly leaned to him through this handing-over again and again. Besides, words like dismissal and removal from office also cluster around him. Together they show that he borrowed the imperial order and cleared out his opponents. After the abbreviated name Zhongxian is also counted into the target word, forging edicts rises from 15th to 2nd; this shows that the abbreviation sentences mostly narrate his borrowed-order actions.

As for his overstepping, it shows most clearly in living shrines. The so-called living shrines are to build a temple and give offerings to him while he is still alive, which is almost to raise him to the same place as Confucius; officials passing by even called him Nine Thousand Years (九千岁), which shows how far the flattery went. These were all settled together after his death, written as the treason case. So the groups party, shrine, edict, punishment, case (党、祠、旨、刑、案) are more like several links of the same matter, not several independent kinds.

This framing can be compared with the judgment in the section "the Eunuch Calamity of the Tianqi Reign" (天启朝之阉祸) of Meng Sen's Mingshi jiangyi (明史讲义). Meng Sen thinks the eunuch disaster was not only the personal evil of Wei Zhongxian, but also the result of the decline of the dynasty's fortune and a foolish ruler; he also points out that Wei Zhongxian's power was exercised through the emperor's mouth, for example letting Wang Tiqian read Yang Lian's memorial but skipping the key words; in the memorials he was only called "the Palace Servant" (厂臣) without his name; inside the eunuch party there were also several groups fighting each other; and the living shrines and letting Wei Zhongxian share the sacrifice with Confucius were the extreme of flattery. My collocations are partly similar to Meng Sen's view: the Yang Lian on top, and forging edicts, transmitting edicts, his faction, exactly correspond to what he called "borrowing the emperor's mouth" and the faction network. But there is a difference: Meng Sen spreads the responsibility to the fortune and the emperor, while the Mingshi concentrates it on Wei Zhongxian alone. This shows that an official history easily puts a systemic problem onto one person, and the Qing court wanted to say the fall of the Ming was women and eunuchs seizing power, so it needed such a concrete person. So the collocations show how the official history frames him, while Meng Sen gives the historian's later, more neutral re-reading.

Limitations

The conclusion above is also affected by several factors. The first is that the windows 5 and 10 give two definitions of "how near is near", and although the direction of the results is the same, changing the window still matters. I keep only sentences of five words or more, which loses some short sentences and may lean the result to the longer biographies; the three-word control does not fully remove this bias. Also, the way of handling the full name and the abbreviation changes the ranking, and the influence on forging edicts and transmitting edicts is especially clear. Deleting the name list at the beginning of each juan is reasonable, but after all it is also a deletion, and it will affect the result to some degree. The most important point is that collocations alone cannot show what Wei Zhongxian actually did; they only reflect how the official text describes him, that is, the voice of the historians and the Qing court, and cannot hear the voices of those who were suppressed. So this study gives only the official history's perspective, not history itself.

References

Meng Sen. *Mingshi jiangyi*. Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1981, chapter 6, section 2.

Zhang Tingyu (张廷玉) et al. *Mingshi*. Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1974.